



MENTAL HEALTH TRENDS FROM SURVEY DATA

IMPACT OF SOCIAL EXCLUSION AND INCLUSION

Access to technology is now a vital necessity rather than a luxury in our increasingly digital environment. An individual's capacity to manage their health, including mental well-being, keep informed, interact with services, and develop communities may be hampered by digital isolation. This exclusion can result in exacerbated forms of social marginalization and mental health decline for vulnerable groups, including low-income families, local communities, and individuals with disabilities.

Therefore, digital inclusion encompasses both fair access to digital technologies and the ability to use them effectively. Conversely, social exclusion refers to more extensive systemic obstacles that keep people from fully engaging in society, whether they be racial, economic, geographic, or otherwise. The intersection of these exclusionary practices has a profound effect on mental health outcomes.

PUBLIC HEALTH EVIDENCE AND RESEARCH

Australian Digital Inclusion Index (2023)

According to the ADII, digital inclusion remains uneven across Australia. The data reveals that people living in regional and remote Victoria, low-income households, older Australians, and individuals with disabilities consistently score lower on digital inclusion metrics.

These groups face multiple barriers:

- Affordability of devices and internet plans
- Limited digital literacy or confidence in using technology
- Lack of stable connectivity

Digital exclusion results in reduced participation in education, healthcare, employment, and even civic engagement. Importantly, it leaves individuals isolated from vital online mental health resources, peer support groups, and information hubs that others take for granted.

ABS National Study of Mental Health and Wellbeing (2021)

This major Australian study found that 15% of people aged 16–85 experienced a mental disorder in the previous 12 months. The rates were significantly higher among those



reporting social isolation, economic hardship, and reduced digital access. For example, individuals with poor digital literacy reported feeling disconnected and experienced higher psychological distress.

VicHealth Mental Wellbeing Strategy

VicHealth, a pioneer in public health innovation, highlights digital access and social inclusion as protective factors for mental wellbeing. Their strategy promotes:

- Socially connected communities
- Digitally literate youth and seniors
- Culturally and linguistically diverse (CALD) population outreach

Research from VicHealth finds that people with access to strong community networks and positive digital experiences are more resilient, more likely to seek help, and more engaged in proactive mental health behaviours.

Their policy interventions call for designing technology with equity in mind, ensuring tools are intuitive, affordable, and culturally inclusive, especially for rural and underserved communities.

MDPI Study on Social Exclusion (2023)

A peer-reviewed study published in “Children” (MDPI) found that adolescents facing social exclusion exhibited higher depression, emotional dysregulation, and lower academic performance. These effects persisted into early adulthood, influencing career opportunities and social development. The authors suggest that inclusive digital platforms and peer recognition can serve as buffers.

The study concluded that early experiences of exclusion lead to long-term mental health issues that persist into adulthood, affecting employability, self-esteem, and identity development. Importantly, the authors advocate for inclusive digital platforms, where peer connection and recognition can act as buffers against psychological harm.

Heinz, Zhao & Liu (2022): Global Psychiatric Perspective

In their study “Implications of the Association of Social Exclusion With Mental Health”, the authors concluded that chronic social exclusion can biologically alter stress regulation pathways in the brain, especially in the amygdala and prefrontal cortex, making individuals more susceptible to depression, PTSD, and anxiety disorders. They argue that digital interventions can act as social reinforcers.



The study powerfully argues that social connection and digital inclusion should be treated as mental health interventions, not luxuries.

REFERENCES

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